

Reporting on Your Project

On completion of your project, you may be required to submit a written report or deliver a presentation about the project to key stakeholders.¹ You can use this opportunity to show how well you met your original objectives, highlight the value of what you have delivered and share any lessons you learned along the way.

Preparing a written report

A written report allows you to provide a comprehensive account of your project, including your objectives, activities, results and any conclusions or recommendations. The project report should highlight your successes – this is your chance to showcase everything you’ve achieved. But as well as reflecting on your accomplishments, the report should also consider any challenges you may have encountered and look forward to future projects.

When you’re preparing the report, ask yourself questions such as ‘What went well?’ and ‘What could we have done better?’ Sharing these lessons with others in the business can help them to avoid having the same issues when they manage their own projects.

The report should be well structured, with clear headings and subheadings, and use appropriate language and formatting to convey your message effectively. Crucially, the document should be easy for someone with no prior knowledge of the project to understand. This means avoiding jargon or technical language that your audience may not be familiar with.

A typical project report might look like this:

Project: Website redesign

Project goal: To overhaul the company’s website by improving the user experience, search engine optimisation (SEO) and overall brand image.

Project timeline: Six months

Key deliverables:

- Website audit and analysis
- New website design and development
- Content creation and optimisation
- Launch followed by post-launch monitoring

¹ Kendrick, T. (2022). The project management tool kit: 100 Tips and techniques for getting the job done right. 3rd edition. New York, NY: AMACOM.

What worked:

- **User-centric design:** The redesigned website prioritised user needs by providing intuitive navigation, which resulted in increased user engagement
- **SEO optimisation:** Effective SEO strategies improved website visibility in search engine results, which drove organic traffic
- **Enhanced brand consistency:** The new website aligned with the company's overall brand identity to create a cohesive online presence

What did not work:

- **Technical challenges:** Some technical issues arose during the development process, which caused delays and required additional troubleshooting
- **Content migration errors:** A few errors occurred during the migration of existing content to the new website, which resulted in temporary disruptions
- **Limited internal resources:** Insufficient internal resources for website maintenance and ongoing updates hindered post-launch optimisation efforts

Ways to improve:

- **Thorough technical planning:** Conducting a more comprehensive technical assessment before starting the redesign would have helped to anticipate potential challenges
- **Content migration testing:** Implementing rigorous testing procedures could have helped to ensure accurate and error-free content migration
- **Dedicated website team:** The project would have benefited from a team responsible for website maintenance, updates and ongoing optimisation

Overall assessment: The website redesign project successfully achieved its goals of improving user experience, SEO and brand image. While challenges were encountered during the development and migration phases, the project positively impacted the website's performance and contributed towards overall business objectives.

Know your audience

The report format gives you the opportunity to go into as much detail as you think is relevant to your stakeholders. However, you should tailor the content of the report to your intended audience.

For example, the level of technical detail you include may vary depending on whether you are presenting to senior executives or the project team. Likewise, the emphasis you place on different aspects of the project might change based on the interests and priorities of your audience. Board members may be more interested in how the project has impacted the company's bottom line, for example, while operations staff are likely to prefer to read about the project's impact on processes and procedures.

By understanding your audience's needs, you can ensure that your report is informative and engaging for them.

Delivering a presentation

A presentation allows you to communicate the key highlights of your project in a more interactive and engaging way than a written report. It also enables you to respond to questions from your audience and explain any areas that may be unclear.²

However, presentations do not allow you to share as much detail as a written report, so it is important to focus on the 'headlines' and not try to include too much information.

There are many things that go into an effective post-project presentation. Generally speaking, you should aim to include:

- An overview of your project's objectives, timeline and key deliverables
- A summary of the project's successes, highlighting the value delivered and the positive impact on the business
- A discussion of any challenges encountered and lessons learned that could benefit future projects
- Recommendations for next steps or areas for improvement
- Time to answer questions from your audience and engage in a constructive dialogue about the project's outcomes

You should begin by briefly reminding everyone of your project's objectives – and why these were important. You might also choose to mention any major changes that you had to make to your goals during delivery and why these were necessary. This will provide the context for the rest of your presentation.

Next, you should discuss the steps involved in managing your project – including details on the human, financial and physical resources you were given, and the tasks and activities you set out to work on. If you created a work breakdown structure or Gantt chart during the planning process, you might choose to show this in the presentation too.

Having shared your project's goals and plan, you can now move on to look at whether or not you achieved your objectives.

If you used quantitative data to evaluate your success, it can be helpful to create some engaging graphics to showcase the impact of your project. For instance, if you can show a deliverable such as fewer customer complaints in the weeks following the delivery of your project, you could illustrate this with a simple graph showing the reduction. Using visual tools like this works well in presentations. They give information in a clear, concise manner that lessens the need for lengthy explanations and allows you to focus on key insights. If your audience has specific questions about

² Harvard Business Review (2014). Managing projects: 20 minute manager. Boston, MA.: Harvard Business Review Press.

your data, you can of course provide more detail – or suggest sending it by email after your presentation.

You should also share any qualitative feedback you received, such as positive testimonials from clients or other stakeholders. This can greatly help to bring your project to life for your audience. While numbers might quantify the impact that your project has had, hearing stories from people whose day-to-day roles have improved can really serve to show why your project has worked and how it has helped people.

As well as highlighting your successes, you also need to acknowledge the challenges you faced. Be honest and transparent here. If any of the risks you identified at the start of the project turned into issues, explain why – and describe the actions you took to resolve them.

If you encountered problems that you had not foreseen, give details about where they came from and how you addressed them. If you experienced major issues that you could not resolve, do not dwell on them. Instead, focus on the valuable lessons you learned and how they might be applied to future projects.

Finally, you should make sure that you set aside some time at the end of the presentation for questions. This allows your audience to seek clarification on points they may have missed or misunderstood and makes sure that everyone leaves with a complete picture of your project. Questions can also help people to delve deeper into specific issues, which may spark discussion and possibly lead to new insights or perspectives that wouldn't otherwise have emerged.

Presentation tips

Here are some tips for making sure that your post-project presentation is as effective as possible:

- **Know your audience** – tailor the content to their level of understanding and interest
- **Structure for clarity** – organise your points logically, so they tell the story of your project
- **Create slides for visualisation** – these should complement what you're saying, not replace it
- **Keep it concise** – use bullet points to highlight the key information, rather than filling your slides with text
- **Use images** – high-quality graphics can engage your audience and reinforce your message
- **Project your voice** – speak clearly and at a moderate pace, avoiding mumbling or speaking too fast
- **Be aware of your body language** – stand tall, make eye contact and use natural gestures to emphasise your points
- **Anticipate questions** – think about what your audience might ask and prepare your responses in advance
- **Make time to practise** – rehearse your presentation so that you feel confident and comfortable in your delivery

It may be that your project review might include both a presentation and a written report. So you can choose to produce a more detailed written report either before or after a presentation to give your audience the best of both worlds.